

Young Eagle Flies With Help From Raptor Center

Volunteers Help Get Bird Back Into The Wild

By PAT BORDEN GUBBINS

Staff Writer

After a six-month convalescence, Queen Midas is back home, soaring over the marshes near Manteo. The young bald eagle is flying free for the first time since she was shot last summer.

A bullet from a high-powered rifle hit her right wing, shattering the bone that corresponds to the human wrist.

The wound was infected when the eagle arrived at the Carolina Raptor Center in July, raising concern that the joint would lock and make future flight impossible. But surgery, antibiotics, good food, TLC and exercise combined to heal the wing.

The last step in the process was the 14-hour round trip from the Raptor Center to the Mattamuskeet National Wildlife Refuge on the Pamlico Sound. Mathias Engelmann, a full-time volunteer who serves as rehabilitation coordinator, and staff member Betty O'Leary left at midnight Friday, Dec. 16.

They arrived in 2 inches of snow. After breakfast and a nap, they set the eagle free at 9:30 a.m. the next day.

"We set her on the ground like we did when we were exercising her," said O'Leary. "She sat there about five minutes and finally took off. She flew about 400 or 500 yards before she finally landed in a pine tree on the other side of the marsh."

"Wildlife people at the park



TOM FRANKLIN/Staff

After six months at the Carolina Raptor Center, this young bald eagle is on the mend.

said they have some eagles staying there year-round," she said. "At their last count, there were 11 juveniles and two adult birds, so she should have some company."

On that Friday morning, Engelmann and two other volunteers took the eagle for her last workout on a farm a few miles north of the Raptor Center at Latta Plantation Park.

Engelmann was sick with a hacking cough. But it was his job to race across a pasture behind the eagle, holding one end of a long, light tow rope attached to her soft leather anklets.

Martha Rockett, an intern five days a week at the center, donned the heavy leather gauntlets in order to handle the eagle without being ripped by its hooked beak or long talons.

As the temperature rapidly dropped and the wind grew bitter, she carried the 10-pound bird through a stand of woods and into an empty pasture. She held Queen Midas while Engelmann attached the anklets, ran along behind during the eagle's long, low flights, and carried her back to the starting

point. They repeated the process for about 45 minutes.

Meredith Hebden provided the transportation to the farm near the Raptor Center and took pictures of the flights, occasionally relieving Rockett by carrying the eagle back up the hill.

Queen Midas announced each lift-off with a harsh "ACK-CAK-CAK-CAK-CAK."

Silent during her low glide, she shrieked with alarm — sounding much like a sea gull — when Rockett picked her up for the trip back up the hill.

Toted upside down in Rockett's arms, the eagle's noises turned to a chortling sound, not unlike a chicken's.

"She's saying, 'Why-y-y don't you take these anklets off? I'm just a poor, weak bird. Trust me,'" joked Hebden.

Queen Midas is a juvenile, indicated by her brown eyes, black beak, brown head and tail feathers.

In five or six years, her eyes and beak will turn gold; her head and tail feathers will become white. At maturity, her wingspread will measure 6 to 7 feet.

Queen Midas was named by her benefactor, Midas Spring Water Inc. of Beatties Ford Road, which donated \$300 to "adopt" her and pay for her care. Adoption costs are based on the expense of caring for different birds and range from the eagle's cost to \$35 for a screech owl.

"We put a lot of effort into taking care of the birds, especially bald eagles because they are an endangered species," said Pat Marcum, executive director of the Raptor Center.

"There's no way we can charge a fee for taking care of an injured bird. It helps when someone adopts a bird because that covers the medical care of the bird, the food, time and effort we put in."

The Raptor Center leases property from the county at Latta Plantation Park to provide care for birds of prey — eagles, hawks, buzzards, peregrine falcons, owls. But it depends almost entirely on donations, "adoptions" of birds, memberships and sales from its gift shop to cover the bills.

"We are constantly in need of donations to meet our budget," Marcum said. "We are truly an organization that is funded by the people." More than 100 volunteers help with rehabilitation, daily care, transportation and other needs.

The center usually has 175 to 200 raptors to care for. Between 300 and 400 of the birds of prey are brought to the center for treatment each year. Each has its own chart and hospital bracelet. While

under medical treatment, they stay in draped cages in the intensive care room to keep them as quiet as possible.

The center has another eagle that may be releasable. Adopted by the Verbatim Corp., the eagle is a female born last winter. Apparently a poor hunter and near starvation, she landed in someone's yard in Davie County and was brought to the Raptor Center.

"The first year for raptors is the toughest," Marcum said. "That's when they are learning their coping skills, how to hunt. Sixty percent of them don't make it."

Want To Help?

To make a donation, send checks to the Carolina Raptor Center, P.O. Box 16443, Charlotte, N.C. 28297. For information about adopting an injured bird of prey or training to be a volunteer, call the center at 875-6521.

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TOM FRANKLIN/STAFF

Queen Midas is held by Carolina Raptor Center volunteer Martha Rockett. The bald eagle was been returned to Manteo after recuperating from a gunshot wound at the raptor center.

light tow rope attached to her soft leather anklets.

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